

UTT Chapter 17 Assignment

Greetings!

Your last letter helped me out a ton when writing my economics paper. Thanks a lot! Now I just have to focus on surviving these last few weeks of the semester. Elections are held next week, and finals are held the following three weeks. Surprisingly, this week will be relatively low key, like the calm before the storm. My professors have been helpful with supplying extra office hours in preparation for finals. In fact I met with my History of Western Civilization professor yesterday to talk about some questions I had concerning next week's studies on the French Revolution. He is an interesting old man with a British accent and a penchant for wearing tweed coats and bow ties.

During our conversation, I mentioned how his class has me considering perhaps majoring or minoring in history. He described what it was like to be a historian, digging in archives and spending long hours poring over forgotten texts. He also related his favorite travel memories while researching his latest book. Apparently historians travel the world and learn many languages. An overwhelming topic of our conversation was the method of viewing and analyzing history. Essentially, he was explaining how historians view the overarching theme of history. He views history through the lens of progression. He related it to evolutionary theory. History is always changing, or progressing, as human beings evolve. When I asked him what the end goal of the progression was, he merely chuckled and replied, "progress." Evolution has no purpose, only direction.

The professor's view of history doesn't seem to align with what Christianity says about human depravity and God's redemptive plan for humanity. I told the professor I believed history had meaning and purpose to it. He challenged to me prove it. I told him I was a Christian, but he didn't seem to accept that as an answer. He gave me several books to read on the topic by authors he described as leading humanist and Marxist scholars of history. I assume he means Secular Humanists. I want to be able to speak with him further on these topics, but I need your help understanding the subject better. **What is the Secularist view of history?** Also, **what is the Marxist view of history?** He has mentioned in class before that some historians promote the idea that history is only the interpretations we impart onto the subject. This sounds like something Paige, as a Postmodernist, would say. **How does Postmodernism approach the discipline of history?** Nathan is taking this class with me, so I want to be prepared to talk with him too. **How does New Spirituality view history?** I also wonder how similar Islam is to Christianity with regards to history. **How do Islamic and Christian views of history differ?**

Thanks again for all your help. I appreciate how much time you spend aiding my understanding of all these different topics. You rock!

See ya!

-Doug

Doug brought up five different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What is the Secularist view of history?

Secularism's view of history can be summed up in just two words: social progress. **Social progress** is the belief that society will continually improve through human initiative. Secularism assumes that history is a long series of continual improvements leading the way to a better tomorrow. Since most Secularists reside in the West, they can't help but feel optimistic about the future. Gross domestic product is rising; technology is advancing; medicine is extending the average life expectancy. Because of human initiative, things are steadily getting better and better. Human beings have evolved biologically into the most intelligent beings on the planets. Along the way we have not only discovered the laws of the universe, we have figured out how to manipulate them for our own betterment. We aren't just evolving biologically anymore; we are directing the very evolution of our society. Secularists don't look for meaning in religion. They don't look to the divine for future salvation. There is no inherent meaning to life or purpose to history. For Secularism, history is about the future. Highly intelligent human beings have the ability to create meaning and the foresight to guide our own existence. Although atoms ultimately determine our fate (**determinism**), we somehow have the freedom (**free will**) to alter the course of human history. According to Secularism, humanity has basically become its own divine savior. [17.4]

2. What is the Marxist view of history?

The main thing that distinguishes Marxism's view of history from Secularism's view of history is its destination. Secularists are fairly optimistic about society's progression; Marxists are utterly convinced that society is evolving toward a very specific outcome: communism. Marxism's view of history is shaped by their belief in **dialectical materialism**. All of reality is matter and one of the inescapable laws of matter is the **dialectic**; thesis and antithesis clash to produce a synthesis, which in turn becomes a thesis. The resulting thesis will eventually clash with its own antithesis and form a new thesis. **Historical materialism** is the belief that society is guided by the dialectic through a series of progressing social and economic phases: tribalism, slavery, feudalism, capitalism, socialism, and ultimately communism. Although Marxists believe that the coming of communism is completely determined, their worldview necessitates at least a modicum of free will. To progress from capitalism to socialism, a messy revolution is necessary. And revolutions need revolutionaries. According to Marxism, human beings are free to make choices that ultimately advance to cause of communism. The task of the historian is to organize facts about the past to show the futility of opposing this inevitability. [17.5]

3. How does Postmodernism approach the discipline of history?

Postmodernism denies that academic objectivity is possible. Since everyone is a biased construction of his or her own situation, no one can be impartial about gathering and organizing historical facts. Moreover, since Postmodernists deny that we can have direct knowledge of reality itself, they go so far as to deny the very concept of “facts.” Truth is illusive; all historical accounts are merely works of subjective fiction. Histories are therefore seen as tools of propaganda, used to wield power over others. And the Postmodernist believes it his job to shed light on this situation. The first task of the Postmodern historian is to deconstruct the works of history (a) demonstrating how objectivity is impossible and (b) revealing the biased motives behind historians. The second task of the Postmodern historian is to retell history from the vantage point of the oppressed. **Historical revisionism** is the act of reinterpreting the past to serve an ideological purpose. Marxists and Postmodernist both reinterpret history from the vantage point of oppressed groups—the former with concern for the working class and the latter with concern for repressed groups (e.g. women, minorities, gays). [17.6]

4. How does New Spirituality view history?

Like Marxists and Secularists, New Spiritualists believe that human history is progressing in a purposeful direction. For the New Spirituality, this *telos* is oneness with the divine. **Cosmic evolution** is the belief that humanity is evolving both biologically and spiritually. **Evolutionary godhood** is the belief that we are progressing through history toward the ultimate goal of realizing our own divinity. According to New Spiritualists, we can accelerate our evolutionary spiritual progression by seeking higher consciousness. As we become more enlightened, we move past the primitive religions of our ancestors (e.g. Judaism, Christianity, and Islam). We will eventually realize that consciousness is all that exists. When enough of us attain enlightenment, everything and everyone becomes absorbed into collective consciousness, and we will all be better off. [17.7]

5. How do Islamic and Christian views of history differ?

Islam teaches that history is divinely determined by the will of Allah. **Pan-Islam** is the belief that the world should be united under a global Islamic state. More radical Muslims believe this inevitability justifies using **jihad**. By this, they mean that Muslims are free to pursue the establishment of Islam throughout the world, using any means necessary, because it is ultimately God’s will to bring everyone into obedience. According to Islamists, all people will eventually submit to Allah, and the dutiful Muslim should be willing to help make this happen.

Muslims believe that God is free to intervene in history, but that he is ultimately unknowable and unpredictable. According to Christianity, God has made himself known—not exhaustively, but predictably. Christianity sees history as the epic unfolding of God’s divine plan. The **redemptive narrative** is the sequence of God’s grand metanarrative: God created everything good; humanity rebelled and creation exists in a fallen state; God sent his son to redeem humanity; this set in motion a counter-trend in history by which all things are being restored and reconciled to Christ. The Christian God doesn’t ask us to force others to submit. God has given humanity the opportunity to participate in his Kingdom. It is the job of the obedient Christian to share this opportunity with others. [17.8–17.9]